

19TH YEAR ON EARTH



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Hello

Before we begin...
How are you, really?

ABOUT THE AUTHOR



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Hi, I'm Rishi — a creator, storyteller, and explorer at heart. Through my platform Rishi Explores, I share raw and honest reflections on life, growth, and self-discovery. Once an introvert and “average student,” my journey taught me that imperfection is not weakness but a starting point.

Whether through writing, podcasts, or videos, my goal is simple: to keep it real, inspire honest conversations, and remind people that figuring life out is part of the adventure.

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INTRODUCTION

This book is a reflection of that process. It's about the doubts we carry, the lessons we learn, and the courage it takes to keep moving forward even when the destination isn't clear.

As you read these pages, I hope you find not instructions, but inspiration. Not rules, but reminders — that your story matters, your struggles have meaning, and your journey, however uncertain, is worth embracing.



Every thought, every confusion, every spark
together they sketch the person I am becoming.

IDENTITY ?

Who am I?

It sounds like such a simple question, yet it has followed me like a shadow. Not just in classrooms where teachers asked me to introduce myself, but in the quietest corners of my mind when no one was watching.

At nineteen, identity feels less like a word and more like a maze. Some days, I wake up sure of who I want to be. Other days, I stare at the ceiling wondering if I even know myself at all.

Everyone around me seems to have answers. Parents with expectations. Friends with plans. Teachers with advice. Society with labels — student, achiever, failure, average. And in the middle of all these voices, I sometimes lose my own.

Am I just the grades I scored last semester? The career path people think I should choose? The version of myself I post online? Or is there something deeper that even I haven't met yet?

The truth is, I don't fully know. And maybe that's okay. Maybe identity isn't something you suddenly discover one fine morning. Maybe it's something you build — through mistakes, friendships, failures, and tiny victories no one else notices.

This book is a reflection of that process. It's about the doubts we carry, the lessons we learn, and the courage it takes to keep moving forward even when the destination isn't clear.

As you read these pages, I hope you find not instructions, but inspiration. Not rules, but reminders — that your story matters, your struggles have meaning, and your journey, however uncertain, is worth embracing.

Because at the end of the day, identity isn't a single word. It's a story. And this — right here, right now — is mine.

CHAPTER I

DREAMS

**DREAMS ARE THE ONLY THINGS THAT LET US LIVE TWICE
ONCE IN REALITY, AND ONCE INSIDE OUR HEADS.**

When I was a kid, my dream wasn't small. I didn't just want to pass exams, or get into some safe career. I wanted to be a scientist. I wanted my name written in history books, not in attendance registers. I imagined myself standing in front of inventions the world had never seen, speaking to crowds who whispered my name with respect.

In those days, nothing felt impossible. You could build rockets out of cardboard, draw galaxies on the last page of your notebook, and believe that one day they would be real. Childhood has a strange innocence like that — it lets you dream without thinking about the weight of the world.

But then... the world starts speaking. Teachers, relatives, even neighbors begin to measure your worth in percentages and ranks. Suddenly, “dreams” sound like luxury, and “marks” sound like survival. I realized very early that society loves successful people — but only if they succeed in the approved way. A scientist? Too risky. An inventor? Too uncertain. The world prefers doctors, engineers, or government employees. Safe choices. Predictable choices. Choices that kill curiosity one exam at a time.

Still, my dream didn't die. It became like a stubborn shadow, following me even when I tried to ignore it. Late at night, when the world was asleep, I would close my eyes and see myself in a lab coat, working on something the world wasn't ready for. In those moments, I felt alive again.

But mornings came. With alarms, homework, and the reality of being “just another student.” I’d open textbooks that felt heavier than my dreams. I’d see classmates competing, not for ideas, but for numbers. I’d sit in classrooms where curiosity was replaced with silence, where asking questions felt like a rebellion.

And yet... even in that silence, the dream whispered. “Don’t forget me. Don’t bury me. Don’t let them take me away.”

Some dreams are like seeds buried under concrete. They don’t vanish; they wait. They wait for the day cracks appear in the cement, and they find the courage to grow again. My dream of becoming a scientist still waits inside me. Maybe the world will laugh, maybe life will pull me in other directions, but I know one thing: the child who wanted to build empires out of ideas is still alive.



And maybe that’s what a dream really is — not just an ambition, but a stubborn piece of your soul that refuses to die, no matter how much reality tries to kill it.

CHAPTER II

CONFUSION

Everyone kept asking me the same question —

“What’s next?”

Like life came with a pre-drawn map I was too lazy to open.

But here’s the truth: I didn’t even know where I was standing.

It felt like being trapped in a hedge maze, where every path looked the same and every turn only led to more walls. I could hear the voices of my friends — some talking about big careers, others already applying to colleges, a few chasing dreams with a certainty I couldn’t even fake. Their footsteps sounded confident, like they knew the way out.

And me?

I was still standing at the first turn, staring at the walls, wondering if confusion had secretly become my permanent address.

Some days, I told myself it was normal. Nobody actually has it figured out. Maybe everyone else was just pretending better. Other days, the doubt grew louder — maybe I was falling behind, maybe I was the only one lost while the world kept moving ahead without me.

That’s when another monster crept in —
comparison.

Growing up, no one warns you that comparison is a disease. It starts small — a test score, a trophy, a random comment from a relative: “Look at him, look at her.”

And before you know it, confusion isn't just about what you want — it's about whether what you want is good enough compared to someone else.

I remember staring at my marks, not because I cared, but because someone else's number was higher. I remember scrolling late at night, not celebrating my friends' wins but secretly asking, "Why not me?"

Comparison turned my confusion into chaos. It made me doubt my own pace, my own journey. I started running on a track that wasn't even mine, forgetting that life isn't a single race where we all share the same finish line.

The worst part? Comparison blinds you. You stop seeing your own strengths, your own uniqueness. You forget that everyone's story is different, and what you're envying is just someone else's highlight reel, not their whole struggle.

So confusion wasn't just about not knowing the road ahead — it was about staring at everyone else's road and thinking mine wasn't enough.

But maybe that's what confusion teaches you: that the only person you need to outgrow is who you were yesterday.

Because being lost is scary. But being lost in someone else's path? That's worse.

So yes, at eighteen, I was lost. I still am, in many ways. But maybe being lost isn't the end of the story. Maybe it's the storm before the compass shows itself. Maybe confusion — and even comparison — aren't failures. Maybe they're just the first steps toward direction.

Until then, I'll keep walking, even if I don't know where the road leads.

Some days, being confused felt like being directionless.

I'd wake up, attend classes, submit assignments, tick off deadlines —

but deep inside, I kept asking, "Why am I even doing this?"

Friends already had their paths named: Doctor, IAS, MBA.

And me? I was just... standing still.

Smiling on the outside, lost on the inside.

It felt like holding a map without the "You are here" point.

Running endlessly on a treadmill — moving, sweating, exhausting but never arriving anywhere.

Maybe directionless isn't failure.

Maybe it's just the fog before sunrise,
the blank page before the story begins.



CHAPTER III

FRIENDSHIP

At this age, friendships feel like lifelines. They're the people you laugh with until your stomach hurts, the ones you call at midnight when the world feels too heavy, the ones who sit beside you in silence and somehow that silence feels enough.

But friendships are also fragile. Some slip away quietly, like sand falling through fingers. Some break loudly, with fights and words you can't take back. And some... simply fade without warning, leaving only the echo of what once was.

I used to think friendships were forever. That the people I sat with in class, shared chai with, or walked home with would always be there. But life has a cruel way of proving otherwise. College choices, family expectations, ambitions, egos—time throws storms, and not every friendship survives them.

And then, there are fake friends. The ones who smile to your face but compete behind your back. The ones who cheer when you fail, even if they clap when you succeed. The ones who stick around when things are easy but vanish when you're at your lowest. Their friendship feels warm at first, but slowly you realize it's a mask—plastic smiles, hollow promises. And nothing hurts more than realizing someone you trusted was wearing a disguise all along. Yet even those betrayals teach you something. They sharpen your eyes. They remind you that loyalty is rare, that not every “bro” means brother, and not every “bestie” is forever.

Still, I can't deny the beauty of the real ones. The friends who didn't care about my grades, my failures, or the image I showed to the world. The ones who saw the broken parts of me and didn't flinch. They didn't fix me, but they stayed — and sometimes, staying is enough.

Friendships at this age aren't just about fun. They are mirrors. They show us who we are, and sometimes, who we don't want to be. Some friends pull you forward, push you to dream bigger. Some pull you down, tie you to the ground. And some simply walk with you for a while, leaving footprints beside yours before taking another path.



The truth is, not all friendships last forever. But maybe that's not the point. Maybe they're meant to be chapters, not the whole story. Each one shaping us, carving us, teaching us. So I've stopped asking, "Will this friendship last?" Instead, I ask, "What is this friendship teaching me now?" Because whether they stay, leave, or betray — friends at this age leave marks. And maybe that's the real magic — That we carry pieces of each other into the future, even if we don't walk there together.

CHAPTER IV

THE TURNING POINT

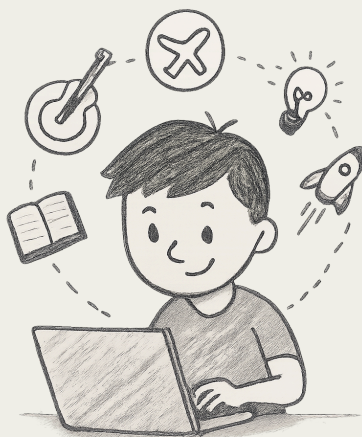
Lockdown impacted people in many different ways. For some, it was a pause they never asked for; for others, it was a silence that felt heavier than noise. But for me, it became something else—it turned into my turning point.

Before lockdown, I was already passionate about tech. I loved the idea of gadgets, of how things worked, of being curious about the digital world. But during lockdown, something shifted. Suddenly, I had all this free time, and instead of letting it slip away, I began to explore.



My closest companion in those days was an old laptop—nothing fancy, just basic specs, but it became my buddy. With it, I started teaching myself things I never imagined I would learn on my own. I picked up Python, line by line, error by error, until code started making sense. I explored video editing, spending hours stitching together clips, learning how a story can be told not just with words but with visuals and sound. I even wrote articles on my blog, pouring my thoughts onto a blank screen, letting words become another form of expression.

Those days were filled with discovery. Every little topic that caught my attention became a rabbit hole I gladly fell into. From researching the latest gadgets to understanding the basics of programming, I went deep. And for the first time, I realized how much I loved learning — not because someone told me to, not for exams, not for marks, but for myself.



Looking back, I see how those quiet days shaped me. The world outside was stuck, but inside, I was moving forward. That was my turning point. The moment I stopped just being curious about tech and actually began creating, learning, and building. And maybe that's the beauty of turning points — they don't always arrive with loud announcements. Sometimes, they come silently, in the form of free time, an old laptop, and the will to make something out of nothing.

CHAPTER V

SHADOWS IN SILENCE

I've always been the quiet one.

The one who sits at the edge of conversations, listening more than speaking.

Not because I don't have thoughts—if anything, my mind is a storm of them.

But when the moment comes to share, my words freeze. My heart races, my voice weakens, and before I know it, silence takes over.

It's strange how silence can be louder than words.

When I don't speak, people assume I have nothing to say.

And slowly, I become invisible.

In groups, my presence fades to the background.

Even when I gather courage and finally say something, someone else's voice overshadows mine, and my words vanish into thin air.

Ignored. Forgotten. As if they were never spoken.

And it hurts.

Because deep down, I wish to be free.

I wish to laugh loudly without overthinking, to walk into a room without shrinking, to speak and actually be heard.

But the moment I try, a wall rises inside me—nerves, doubts, fear of judgment.

I end up staying silent, watching the world move like a movie I'm too afraid to act in.

People call me introverted, as if it's a neat little label.

But they don't see the battles behind it—the nights I replay conversations I never had, the mornings I promise myself, "Today I'll talk more," only to end up retreating again.

They don't see how heavy it feels to carry words that never leave my mouth.

Being ignored doesn't always happen because others are cruel. Sometimes it happens because my silence builds the walls for them.

Still, the pain is real.

The feeling of being unseen in a crowd, unheard in a conversation, forgotten in a moment.

It's like standing in a room full of people and holding a sign that says, "I exist," yet no one notices.

But here's the thing I'm slowly learning —
Silence isn't weakness.

My quiet doesn't mean I lack value.

My words may not always be loud, but when they finally come out, they hold depth.

And maybe being an introvert isn't about breaking free of who I am, but about finding the courage to let my voice shine in my own way, in my own time.

For now, I'm still trying.

Trying to speak a little louder.

Trying to trust that my words matter.

And even if I stumble, even if I'm overshadowed again —
I'll keep reminding myself:

I may be quiet, but I am not invisible.



CHAPTER VI

THE WEIGHT I COULDN'T NAME

There are days when I smile on the outside,
but inside, I'm sinking.

A heaviness presses down on me, the kind you can't put
into words.

It's not just sadness.

It's something deeper—like carrying a backpack full of bricks
that no one else can see.

The worst part?

I couldn't tell anyone.

Because how do you explain to people that you're drowning when
they only see you standing on dry land?

How do you confess that your mind feels like a storm when they
expect you to act normal?

So, I stayed silent.

I laughed when I had to, nodded when they spoke, and hid the
chaos behind practiced smiles.

There were nights when I stared at the ceiling, wondering if this
weight would ever leave me.

Nights where my chest felt too tight, my thoughts too loud, and
my hope too dim.

I wanted to scream, but the words never came out.

I wanted to cry for help, but the world was asleep.

And in that silence, I convinced myself—
maybe no one would understand anyway.

Depression is strange.

It doesn't always look like crying or breaking down.

Sometimes, it looks like scrolling endlessly on your phone.

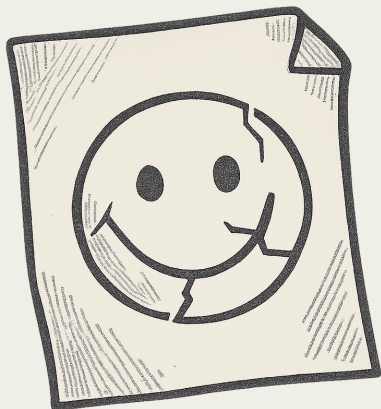
Sometimes, it looks like sleeping too much, or not at all.

Sometimes, it looks like laughing at jokes while secretly wondering if you'll ever feel truly happy again.

And the scariest part?

You start to feel guilty for even feeling this way.

"You have food, shelter, people who care — what right do you have to be sad?"



So the weight doubles — pain on one side, guilt on the other.

And you carry both in silence.

But here's what I'm slowly learning:

Depression doesn't make me weak.

It doesn't make me broken.

It makes me human.

And maybe I don't need to have all the answers or explanations.

Maybe surviving the day, even when it feels impossible, is its own kind of courage.

I still haven't figured it out.

There are days the weight feels unbearable.

But every time I choose to wake up, to breathe, to keep moving, I'm proving to myself —

that even in the darkest nights, I can hold on until morning.



STILL BECOMING

Nineteen years.

Not a perfect journey. Not a straight road. Just a collection of crooked paths, pauses, questions, and moments that stitched me into who I am today.

I once thought life was about reaching some destination — becoming someone final, certain, complete. But the truth I've learned is this: we are never complete. We are always becoming.

Dreams may shift. Friends may come and go. Confusion may cloud our vision, and silence may weigh on us. Yet, through it all, the one thing that remains is movement — the choice to take one more step, even when the road is dark.

If the first 18 years taught me anything, it is this: life isn't about answers. It's about courage. Courage to try. Courage to fail. Courage to wake up again tomorrow and ask, "What can I create today?"

So here I stand, at the edge of my 19th year on Earth. Not with certainty, but with hope. Not with a map, but with a compass stitched from lessons, mistakes, and memories.

Maybe that's enough.

Maybe it has always been enough.

Because the journey was never about who I should be — it was always about daring to be me.

A NOTE OF GRATITUDE

To my **parents** — thank you for your endless love, patience, and belief. Even when I doubted myself, you never stopped believing in me. Every page here carries a piece of your sacrifices and your strength.

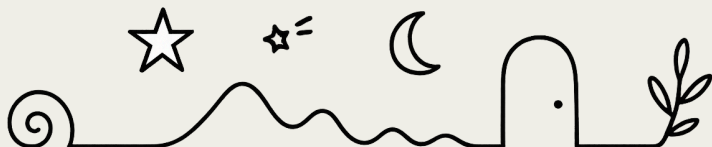
And to the people of **Velgatoor**, the place where I grew up — thank you for making my childhood special. The laughter, the streets, the warmth of neighbors, the festivals, the memories of ordinary days that somehow feel extraordinary now — they are the roots that keep me grounded, no matter where I go.

To my English faculty, **Hepsiba Ma'am** — thank you for being more than a teacher. You didn't just correct my words; you shaped the way I see them. You gave me the courage to write, to express, to search for meaning in sentences when I often struggled to find meaning in myself. Without your guidance, this book would have stayed just a dream.

This book is not just mine. It's a reflection of everyone who touched my life, who shaped me in ways big and small. To each of you

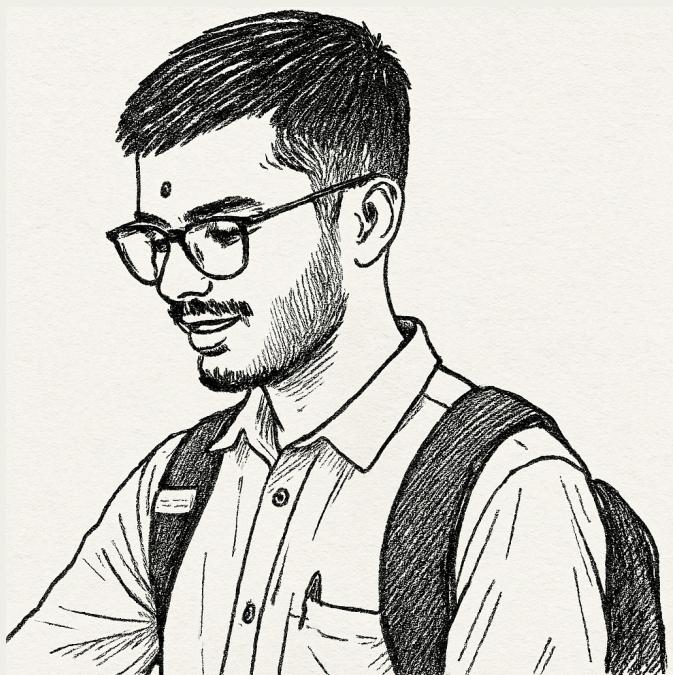
— **thank you.**

SWAMY SHARANAM AYYAPPA



AFTER EVERYTHING YOU'VE READ...
WHAT TRUTH DID YOUR HEART WHISPER TO YOU?

**FORGET WHAT THE WORLD THINKS.
DO WHAT YOUR HEART KNOWS IS RIGHT.
DO WHAT MAKES YOU QUIETLY HAPPY.**



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